Hunting Snake

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‘Hunting Snake’

Here is a detailed guide to Judith Wright's poem 'Hunting Snake', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods**: an exploration of Wright’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas within Wright's poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Judith Wright’s intention and message

‘Hunting Snake’ overview

Judith Wright’s poem ‘Hunting Snake’ describes an encounter between two walkers and a snake that crosses its path. The poem reflects on the mixed emotions resulting from a brief sighting of a dangerous but beautiful predator in the wild.

‘Hunting Snake’ breakdown

Lines 1-3

> **“Sun-warmed in this late season’s grace**
> **under the autumn’s gentlest sky**
> **we walked, and froze half-through a pace.”**

Translation

they suddenly stop

Wright's intentions

- The poet sets a harmonious and calm scene, full of "grace" under the "gentlest sky"
- This allows for an abrupt mood shift, as "sun-warmed" is contrasted with "froze":
  - The fact that they froze halfway through their steps reinforces the idea of surprise; they were stopped in the middle of action

Line 4

> **"The great black snake went reeling by."**

Translation

- The speaker explains why they stopped walking: a large snake slides by

Wright's intentions

- The end-stopped line conveys tension as a "great black snake" suddenly passes:
  - The word "black" suggests something evil or menacing, juxtaposed with "great" which suggests the watchers experience both fear and awe at the sight of the snake

Lines 5-7

> **"Head down, tongue flickering on the trail**
> **he quested through the parting grass;**
> **sun glazed his curves of diamond scale,"**

Translation

- The next stanza describes the snake in detail:
  - Its tongue flicks across the path as he moves through the grass
- The sun shines on its "diamond" scales as it wriggles its body

Wright's intentions

- The snake is described with imagery that suggests its beauty and strength
- The snake's movements are determined ("head down", it "quested"):
  - A "quest" suggests a noble cause, again reinforcing the mixed feelings of the speaker towards the snake
  - Imagery of precious gems, such as "glazed" and "diamond" implies both reverence and awe

> **"and we lost breath to watch him pass."**

Translation

- As they watch the snake, the speaker and companion become breathless

Wright's intentions

- Again, Wright ends a stanza by turning from a description of nature back to the speaker and their companion's reactions
- The poet describes the experience of seeing a wild animal as moving, which highlights the power of nature

Lines 9–10

> **"What track he followed, what small food
> fled living from his fierce intent,"**

Translation

- The speaker wonders about where the snake is going, and if it is hunting a small animal that has run ("fled") from the snake's "fierce" intention, which is to eat it

Wright's intentions

- Wright's speaker turns inward as they imagine the snake as a frightening predator
- The poem depicts an individual reflecting on the life of a wild animal:
  - The speaker conveys the power of the snake via its "fierce intent"

Lines 11–12

> **"we scarcely thought; still as we stood
> our eyes went with him as he went."**

Translation

- The speaker and their companion are transfixed by the snake
- Although the sighting of the snake is brief, the speaker and their companion are entranced

Wright's intentions

- Wright shows the mixed reactions of humans coming into contact with a dangerous, predatory animal:

Lines 13–16

> **"Cold, dark and splendid he was gone**
> **into the grass that hid his prey.**
> **We took a deeper breath of day,**
> **looked at each other, and went on."**

Translation

- The snake is described as dangerous, yet majestic and beautiful
- The snake goes into the grass to hunt small animals
- At this, the speaker and their companion take a deep breath and acknowledge the moment by looking at "each other" before they continue their walk

Wright's intentions

- Wright returns to the imagery used to describe the snake at the start of the poem
- Wright's description of the observers' breathlessness at seeing the snake alludes to both their own fear, and the profound effect of seeing nature up close:
  - The subtle mention of the look the speaker shares with their walking companion connotes to a mixed sense of relief and wonder

Examiner Tips and Tricks

In the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme, you are rewarded when you show an understanding of the deeper meanings of the poem. To do this, you should try to explore aspects of form and/or structure and/or language, and how the poet's choices reveal attitudes. For example, you could start your essay paragraphs with a point or interpretation, such as "Wright draws attention to the power of nature in her description of a snake crossing a walker's path." Then, support this argument, not just with a quote, but with an analysis of the writer's methods.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

arranged by theme and includes Judith Wright's intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Judith Wright's poem 'Hunting Snake' uses a regular, steady form that reveals each unfolding event as walkers stop to watch a snake cross their trail.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	The poem has four regular quatrains that progress through the speaker's experience in alternating rhyming lines	The poem is a steady and ordered form that mimics the speaker's contemplation about their own reactions to nature

Structure

Wright's poem conveys the mixed reactions of humans seeing a wild, predatory snake.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	Lines that describe the snake use enjambment to mimic the speaker's breathlessness, but caesura and end-stopped lines present a tense and captivated speaker	Wright reflects the awe and fear the speaker feels as they spot a "splendid" snake, highlighting the power of nature to affect ordinary people on a walk

Language

In 'Hunting Snake', Judith Wright uses vivid imagery that highlights the beauty of nature, alongside emotive language that conveys the human being's response to it.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention

	warmed", gentle "sky" with the "cold, dark and splendid", yet "fierce" snake	between humans and nature, highlighting both the pleasure of an autumn walk and the ill-ease brought about by an encounter with a wild animal

Understanding the text

The poetry questions in the CIE Literature for English exam ask for an **informed, personal response**. This means that you will want to develop a **thorough understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations** and **events** so that you can explore the writer's intentions and methods. This section explores the main theme that Judith Wright conveys in her poem 'Hunting Snake':

- Humans and nature

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward an answer that responds "sensitively and in considerable detail" to the way the writer achieves their effects. You are being asked to explore the poem beyond surface meanings to show deeper awareness of ideas and attitudes. So, your points should always be closely linked to the themes in the poem and relevant to the focus of the question, rather than simply listed as factual information.

Humans and nature

- Judith Wright was born in 1915 in Australia:
  - She was a poet, short-story writer, conservationist and campaigner for Aboriginal Australian land rights
- She was a founder of The Wildlife Preservation Society of Queensland
- Her poetry often describes Australia's natural environment:
  - In her poem, 'Hunting Snake', she shows the "grace" of an autumn day, and a "splendid" snake that moves "head-down, tongue flickering on the trail"
- Australia has over a hundred species of snake:
  - The snake described in Wright's poem is likely poisonous
  - It is described as "fierce" and after small "prey"
- In addition, Wright's poetry often covers themes that explore global and societal pressures on individuals, as well as ideas of identity and belonging:

describes the snake with sensory imagery:
  - Yet lines that mention the speaker's response are straightforward, like "looked at each other, and went on."

- Her writing often examines profound moments in life:
  - Her poem, 'Hunting Snake', contemplates the moment a pair of walkers "freeze" and become transfixed with a brief observation of a snake

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: what the question is asking and how to get full marks. You will also find an example of a full, annotated model answer.

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

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